

Bill, here is a corrected copy of the letter (easy) I sent Mary Wilcox, I have done a lot of Thinking lately concerning my own will be glad to hear your comments

Dear Mary,

I have been reading the books listed for this course in June and have to admit,

I am wondering what your stand on them is because Finding them not at all compatible with my understanding of reality. Reading the book No Boundary spurred me to write you, tho Matthew Fox's book was a big disappointment to me also and I will explain why.

In reading the book No Boundary I realized the problem I was having with this whole idea of science being a view of reality. I am enclosing an article which I found excellent by Huston Smith, a well known Religious Studies Professor, which very clearly explains what science can and cannot do. Simply because on the subatomic level there are no boundaries as far as the various particles are concerned does not mean there are no boundaries at other levels of reality. For example, there are very distinct boundaries in both Chemistry and Biology so making a jump to nature and saying there are no boundaries there is illogical and a misuse of science. However, the most critical mistake he makes is to say that since there are no boundaries on the subatomic level that this applies to the spiritual realm as well is appalling presumption.

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That is not all, even given that he is right about this he claims that the highest consciousness one can have is unity consciousness and with this I disagree. This is the highest consciousness one can attain by a naturalistic mysticism but it is leaving out the transcendent and the Holy altogether which can only be attained by grace and love. Love is not even necessary for the attainment of the conscious level Wilber is talking about and I have found those involved in this search for unity consciousness to be basically self-centered since there is no ethic or need to love either God or others.

I do not see anything wrong with using the methods of various cultures in regard to meditation for each has a right to be tried and judged on its own merit. However, it is something akin to spiritual adultery to adopt the metaphysical ideal of another culture for what is at stake is the ethical and moral values. It is a fact that religions constitute a scale of moral and spiritual values. They are stages of humankind's evolution in the religious sphere. There is no religion w/o value or that is intrinsically false but there is no religion of higher value than love.

I believe there are basically three kinds of mystical experience. first is the experience of union with nature. this is the obliteration of the

differentiation between the individuals psychic life and the surrounding nature, ie., subject and object become one. This is the goal of the yoga of patanjali. The characteristic trait is the experience of intoxication, ie, the temporary fusion of oneself with the forces exterior to ones self-consciousness. This can be attained by drugs sometimes (as Huxley) or even the Dionysian orgies are based on this.

The second level of experience is that of the transcendental self and consists of separating the ordinary empirical self from the higher self, which is above all motion and all that belongs to the domain of space and time. The higher self is thus experienced as immortal and free. This is the state that Wilber is talking about. The characteristic trait is that of progressively "coming to one's senses" with the aim of complete sobriety. The Indian school Sankya is the purest form of this. The individual purusha (spirit) is experienced in its separation from Prakriti (matter, all movement, space and time) as immortal and free.

It is with the interpretation of this experience where the problem comes. In Advaita Vedanta (Shankara and T.M.) the experience of the transcendental self is interpreted to be God, or Brachman.

The intuitive experience of the transcendental self does not suffice alone to let us perceive and render us conscious of the spiritual world. The conclusion of the Vedanta in declaring the identity of the transcendental self and the one God is therefore an error due to a confusion of values. Here the image and likeness of God is taken for God, and the experience of the Divine, likewise is taken to be God itself. however, the Sankya group are considered to be atheists in India because they recognize the limits of the experience as that of the individual purusha and do not deny the plurality of purushas. This is the honest understanding in my opinion.

The third level, and in my mind the ultimate, is the experience of the living God.

Christian mystics, the Bhagavad Gita, Ramanuja in India (a pan-entheist), the Jewish mystics, etc, all have this experience. This is union with God in love which implies a substantial duality being essentially at one. The characteristic trait is a synthesis of the intoxication of nature mysticism and the sobriety of the mysticism of the higher self. It is a state of ardent enthusiasm and profound peace or "beatitude". This beatific vision implies the duality of the seer and the seen, on the one hand, and their union or intrinsic oneness on the other. mystical experience. the more complete the the union is.

This is the essence of the theistic The experience is all the more elevated differentiation is, and the more perfect

Thus, there are basically two divisions that can be drawn here in mystical experience, that of a journey into "Being" and that of a

journey into "love".

The idea of being is morally indifferent and is consequently essentially naturalistic.

It implies something passive, ie a given and unalterable fact. However love is basically active and is in no way neutral from the point of view of the moral life, but is in fact the heart itself. However, one cannot know love objectively as you can know being. Love has to be experienced to understand whereas being can be known objectively. This is one of the reasons, I believe, for the popularity of the "New Age" ideas and mysticism as it does not require love, and therefore commitment and humility. The idea of the

Cross is still a stumbling block for many who want to do everything themselves." Since humility is the law of spiritual health (by their fruits you shall know them) it implies consciousness of difference and distance between the center of human consciousness and the center of divine consciousness. Authentic experience of the Divine makes one humble; if there is not humility I seriously question the experience.

The consequences of these "two attitudes of soul" lies in the experience of practical mysticism. He who chooses being will arrive at the experience of repose in Being and since there cannot be two true beings or two separate co-eternal substances but only one being and one substance, the center of false being will be suppressed. The characteristic of this mystical way is that one loses the capacity to cry.

I cannot remember the author, but the book Experience of the No-Self by a Christian (Catholic) woman describes her path into being. She found Meister Eckhart to be the best help here which I find interesting, but agree that Eckhart is on a very different path than most Christian mystics.

The other path, that into love, has the characteristic of the "gift of tears". This is in keeping with the very essence of their mystical experience. Their union with the divine is not an absorption of their being by Divine Being but rather the experience of the breath of the Divine Love, illumination by Divine Love and the warmth of same. In this mystical experience fire meets FIRE. Nothing is extinguished in the human personality but everything is set ablaze with those factors being purged out in the fire of contemplation through the dark nights of soul and spirit (St. John of the Cross.)

This is the experience of legitimate twofoldness or the union of two separate substances in one sole essence. The substances remain separate as long as they are bereft of that which is the most precious in all existence: free alliance in love. The term essence belongs only properly to God, everything else enters into the

category of substance.

In Christian Theology the vision of God takes place in the domain of essence transcending all substance. It is not a fusion but an encounter in the domain of essence in which the human personality (ie, the consciousness of self) remains not only intact and w/o impediment, but also becomes "God by participation" (John of the

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Cross), it becomes most truly itself, one becomes truly human. This is really what I see as the definite superiority of Christian mysticism. For the Christian, and only the Christian, God is revealed to the human consciousness as an eternal Trinity- -the Loving one who loves, the loved one who loves and their love who loves them (Father/Mother, Son, Holy Spirit). Thus describing God as power, wisdom and love (Jewish) is not sufficient. It is because God is love that he admits of no comparison, that he surpasses all. One can speak of the wisdom of love or the power of love but either power or wisdom without love is w/o worth.

Thus, one has to decide which path to take and it seems many are opting for the one into Being because this requires no real surrender of control whereas love always requires suffering and a giving up of control.

This is why I see the importance of Jesus. The crucifixion is the demonstration of the superiority of love over being, as is the resurrection, for it shows that love can restore being. Since Christ, then, it has been possible to really have a relationship with God without losing one's identity or being a monist. Even the Jewish and Sufi mystics tend toward a monistic interpretation of reality because they do not have the concept of God loving the son in the mystic.

John 10:8, "all who came before me are thieves and robbers" could be interpreted to mean that all mystical experience of God (which did happen, of course) before Christ (and after, too, where he is not accepted) is a depersonalization of the human because you do not have the mediating of the Godhead. What I understand the coming of the Kingdom of God which Jesus announced to be about is the fact that now we can have this relationship to God in Christ without being depersonalized. Only the personality can have the gift of tears. To follow through this idea in John 10:10 where Jesus says he came that we might have life more abundantly means that we can now have an intensive life with God as He/she intended.

This brings me to Matthew Fox. I found his book *Original Blessing* acceptable, and probably would have recommended it over the other but there are still some problems. However, I have some serious questions about the *Coming of the Cosmic Christ*. I have no quarrel with the doctrine of panentheism, in fact this has basically been my experience. The problem in *Cosmic Christ* is a sloppiness of thought which throws him into pantheism, very different concept. For example, on p. 57 he says "Panentheism melts the dualism of inside and outside." NO. In

Panentheism their are still boundaries. P. 228, he says 'In the original fireball itself, that the universe wanted us and awaited us eagerly.' If this isn't pantheism, I don't know what is. PanEN theism still acknowledges a dualism and allows for God to be both immanent and transcendent while pantheism leaves out transcendence altogether. In this regard it limits God.
just two examples, but there are others in this regard.

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